

SAFE AND PEACEFUL PLACE MEDITATION

GOALS OF THE EXERCISE

1. Learn the coping skills necessary to bring posttraumatic stress symptoms and addiction under control.
2. Learn and practice a healthy method to achieve deep relaxation that can be used in many situations.
3. Improve ability to cope with stress in a healthy way.
4. Learn to achieve quick relief from posttraumatic stress symptoms.

ADDITIONAL HOMEWORK THAT CAN BE APPLICABLE TO CLIENTS WHO EXPERIENCE PTSD

- Am I Having Difficulty Letting Go?
- Building My Support Network
- Coping with Addiction and PTSD or Other Anxiety Disorders
- Corresponding with My Childhood Self
- Identifying and Using Community Resources
- Identifying Relapse Triggers and Cues
- Is My Anger Due to Feeling Threatened?
- Learning to Self-Soothe
- Moving On with My Life
- My Anxiety Profile
- Physical and Emotional Self-Care
- Use of Affirmations for Change
- Using My Support Network

ADDITIONAL PROBLEMS FOR WHICH THIS EXERCISE MAY BE USEFUL

- Anxiety
- Borderline Traits
- Childhood Trauma
- Chronic Pain
- Grief/Loss Unresolved

- Substance Intoxication/Withdrawal

SUGGESTIONS FOR PROCESSING THIS EXERCISE WITH THE CLIENT

The “Safe and Peaceful Place Meditation” activity is useful for managing stress and anxiety, particularly for people for whom these are chronic. It is also useful for pain management and coping with insomnia. The approach used in this exercise is to guide the client in a personalized multisensory imagery exercise in which he/she creates a mental construct of a safe and peaceful place and practices temporarily withdrawing from engagement with stressors. With practice this exercise can become a very effective method of achieving quick relaxation. This exercise can be used in individual or group therapy and as an opening routine for treatment groups to get clients centered and focused. Follow-up could include an assignment to practice this at home or to teach it to someone else and report back to the therapist and treatment group on the outcomes.

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Do you sometimes wish you could just get away from whatever situation you're in, or from whatever you're thinking and feeling? This is a normal and healthy wish. It may not be practical to actually leave a situation right away, though, and sometimes it's hard to leave our own thoughts and feelings behind even when we do physically go somewhere else.

This exercise will teach you how to get away even when you can't go anywhere. It will guide you through a process of creating a mental picture of a safe and peaceful place where you can temporarily relax, so that you can come back to your situation calm and refreshed. Practice is important. The more you practice this, the better you'll get at it and the better it will work for you. With enough repetition, people have used this to achieve calm and inner peace very quickly even in the midst of great pain, anger, and anxiety.

For many people, it works best to do this with their eyes closed, so you may want to have someone you trust and feel safe with read this to you while you follow the instructions.

1. *Image.* What is a place that makes you feel calm, peaceful, and safe to think about? Please think of the place that best fits this description for you and form a mental picture of this place. It may be a real place you've been to—anything from a favorite beach to your grandparents' kitchen; place you've heard about and would like to go to; or an imaginary place. Whatever is relaxing for you is right for you. Briefly describe this safe and peaceful place.

2. *Emotions and sensations.* Focus on this image or mental picture. What emotions do you feel? What pleasant physical sensations do you feel and where are they located in your body?

3. *Enhancement.* Please explore this imagery in more detail. Take a few moments to savor it with all your senses and enjoy the idea of being in this safe and peaceful place. When you look

around in this place in your mind's eye, what do you see happening? What do you hear? Is it warm or cool? What does the air feel like against your face? Is there a distinctive aroma?

4. *Cue or key word.* Please think of a single word that fits this picture, and keep this word in mind while you again bring up the mental picture, the sights, the sounds, all the sensations of peace and safety and pleasure of this place you've created for yourself. Focus on whatever pleasant things come to each of your senses in turn, keeping this key word in mind. Now let your mind dwell on those pleasant sensations and repeat the key word to yourself over and over. Try blanking out the pleasant place you have been thinking of, then think of the key word, and see how the image comes back to you quickly and vividly. Notice how your body is feeling relaxed.
5. *Coping with mild stress.* Let's test this as a way for you to relax and overcome negative feelings. Blank out your safe and peaceful place again. Now think of a minor annoyance, a situation or person that isn't a big problem but gets on your nerves. What kinds of negative physical sensations are coming to you when you think of this annoyance? Where are they located in your body?

Now think of your key word. Again, think of the safe and peaceful place in your mind's eye that goes with the key word. Think of the visual images, the scenery, and the sounds; think of the pleasant physical sensations. As you think of this, how does your body feel? What is happening to the negative sensations you felt in your body?

6. *Practice.* For the next 2 weeks, please practice this at least twice a day, and use it when you find yourself getting irritated or anxious. You can also use it when you are feeling physical pain or discomfort, or if you have trouble sleeping. As you practice, keep noticing anything about your mental image of the peaceful and safe place that makes it more vivid and more relaxing for you, and keep those details in mind for future times when you do this exercise. As an added help to learning to use it, try teaching it to someone else and see how it works for him/her.
Use this space to record anything you notice or learn about using this meditation exercise.

Be sure to bring this handout to your next therapy session, and be prepared to talk about your thoughts and feelings about the exercise.